Modismos packet

135 everyday Spanish idioms, from the Modismos tool. Print this packet and work on paper.

Name: _____ Date: _____

An **idiom** (*modismo*) is a phrase whose meaning is not the sum of its words. Translated word by word, most idioms sound strange or wrong — that is exactly why they are worth learning. The 135 idioms in this packet come from everyday Spanish across the Spanish-speaking world, so they are useful anywhere Spanish is spoken.

1. Match the idiom to its meaning

Write the letter of the English meaning next to each Spanish idiom.

1. Tomar el pelo	a. to throw in the towel, give up
2. No tener ni idea	b. to be between a rock and a hard place
3. Estar en las nubes	c. to talk nonstop
4. Meter la pata	d. to cost an arm and a leg
5. Echar una mano	e. to be a piece of cake
6. Estar hecho polvo	f. no worries, it's fine
7. No pasa nada	g. to be wiped out, exhausted
8. Ser pan comido	h. to lend a hand
9. Costar un ojo de la cara	i. to put your foot in it, mess up
10. Hablar por los codos	j. to have your head in the clouds
11. Estar entre la espada y la pared	k. to have no clue
12. Tirar la toalla	l. to pull someone's leg, tease

2. Match twelve more

Write the letter of the English meaning next to each Spanish idiom.

1. Ponerse las pilas	a. to hit the roof, make a big fuss
2. Ser uña y carne	b. to be worth it
3. Andar con pies de plomo	c. to sleep like a log
4. Me da igual	d. to rain cats and dogs
5. Echar de menos	e. to be the last straw, the limit
6. Estar al tanto	f. to speak bluntly, not mince words
7. No tener pelos en la lengua	g. to be up to speed, in the loop
8. Ser el colmo	h. to miss someone or something
9. Llover a cántaros	i. it doesn't matter to me, I don't mind
10. Dormir como un tronco	j. to tread carefully
11. Valer la pena	k. to be inseparable, thick as thieves
12. Poner el grito en el cielo	l. to get moving, get your act together

3. Fill in the missing word

Each idiom is missing its last word. Fill it in (the English meaning is a hint).

1. Tomar el _____ *(to pull someone's leg, tease)*
2. No tener ni _____ *(to have no clue)*
3. Estar en las _____ *(to have your head in the clouds)*
4. Meter la _____ *(to put your foot in it, mess up)*
5. Echar una _____ *(to lend a hand)*
6. Estar hecho _____ *(to be wiped out, exhausted)*
7. No pasa _____ *(no worries, it's fine)*
8. Ser pan _____ *(to be a piece of cake)*
9. Costar un ojo de la _____ *(to cost an arm and a leg)*
10. Hablar por los _____ *(to talk nonstop)*
11. Estar entre la espada y la _____ *(to be between a rock and a hard place)*
12. Tirar la _____ *(to throw in the towel, give up)*

4. Which idiom fits?

Read each situation. Write the Spanish idiom that fits it. The hint gives the idiom's meaning — the bank below has the Spanish forms.

Bank: Quedarse de piedra, Ser un hueso duro de roer, Buscarle tres pies al gato, Estar en un aprieto, De película, ¡Qué genial!, ¡Vaya!, ¡No me digas!.

1. Your friend hears surprising news and cannot move or speak for a moment. — idiom: _____ *(hint: to be stunned, frozen in shock)*
2. A math problem resists every attempt, and nobody in class can solve it. — idiom: _____ *(hint: to be a tough nut to crack)*
3. Someone turns a simple plan into a big argument by looking for problems that are not there. — idiom: _____ *(hint: to overcomplicate things, look for trouble)*
4. You promised two friends you would help both at the same time, and now you cannot do either properly. — idiom: _____ *(hint: to be in a tight spot, in a bind)*
5. The sunset over the mountains looks so beautiful it seems unreal. — idiom: _____ *(hint: amazing, like out of a movie)*
6. Your team just won the game in the last minute. — idiom: _____ *(hint: how great! how cool!)*
7. You open a gift and find exactly what you wanted. — idiom: _____ *(hint: wow! (surprise or admiration))*
8. A classmate tells you something so surprising you can hardly believe it. — idiom: _____ *(hint: you don't say! no way!)*

5. Use it in a sentence

Pick five idioms from this packet and write an English sentence that shows what each one means.

1. Poner toda la carne en el asador — *to go all out, give it everything*

2. A fin de cuentas — *in the end, when all is said and done*

3. A diestra y siniestra — *left and right, in all directions*

4. A fondo — *thoroughly, in depth*

5. A gusto — *comfortable, at ease*

6. Review quiz

Write the English meaning of each idiom. No word bank this time.

1. A la larga: _____
2. A la vez: _____
3. A más no poder: _____
4. A más tardar: _____
5. A primera vista: _____
6. A propósito: _____
7. A todo trance: _____
8. Al contrario: _____
9. Al fin y al cabo: _____
10. Al pie de la letra: _____

7. Reflection

Answer in English or Spanish.

1. Pick the idiom from this packet you would actually use, and say when you would use it.

2. Why does translating an idiom word by word usually fail? Give one example from this packet.

3. Write a tiny dialogue (three lines) between two friends that uses two idioms correctly.

Answer key (teachers): packet-modismos-answers.pdf